

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 937

By Stevens

A RESOLUTION to honor and congratulate Tabitha Bates on her selection as a 2026 Extraordinary Educator.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should pause to specially recognize those outstanding teachers who have devoted their careers to providing the highest-quality education for Tennessee's students; and

WHEREAS, Tabitha Bates of Dover is one such estimable educator, who has distinguished herself as a professional of the greatest dedication, ability, and integrity; and

WHEREAS, Mrs. Bates has been selected as a 2026 Extraordinary Educator by Curriculum Associates, a most befitting honor that recognizes the positive influence she has on so many young lives; and

WHEREAS, the Curriculum Associates Extraordinary Educators program is an annual tradition of celebrating and connecting best-in-class educators who demonstrate established criteria; Extraordinary Educators receive local and national recognition, a network of peers from around the country, professional learning opportunities, and the opportunity to attend the Extraordinary Educators Leadership Summit; and

WHEREAS, a fifth-grade math teacher at Dover Elementary School, Tabitha Bates is an extremely talented and compassionate educator who works assiduously to motivate her students to reach their full potential, both as scholars and as citizens; and

WHEREAS, she earned her undergraduate degree from Murray State University and is currently pursuing a degree in educational leadership at Austin Peay State University; and

WHEREAS, during her twenty-three years as an educator, Mrs. Bates has taught mathematics and English language arts; she began her career at Erin Elementary School in Houston County and came on board at Dover Elementary two decades ago; and

WHEREAS, known for her unique approach to teaching both in and out of the classroom, Tabitha Bates firmly believes that all students can learn, no matter their background; she strives to continuously improve her instruction and enhance student learning while making meaningful connections with her students; and

WHEREAS, leveraging i-Ready data to guide instruction, identify areas for intervention and enrichment, and support meaningful goal setting with her students, Mrs. Bates has seen significant gains among her students in the past two years on the i-Ready Diagnostic and the TCAP state assessment, with some reaching grade-level proficiency after years of struggle; and

WHEREAS, Tabitha Bates is the founder of Panther Pantry, a program she launched four years ago to support students and families in need by providing food, hygiene products, and other essential resources; she created the pantry in remembrance of her father, and today, she runs the pantry with the help of a dedicated team of students, the guidance counselor, and a fellow teacher, making it a school-wide effort in compassion and service; and

WHEREAS, Mrs. Bates enjoys the love and support of her husband of twenty-four years, Casey Bates, and her son, Montana Bates; she is active in her church and guided by her faith in all she does; and

WHEREAS, Tabitha Bates is an inspiration to her colleagues and students alike, and her friendship and counsel are highly valued by those who are fortunate to know her; and

WHEREAS, Mrs. Bates truly epitomizes the dedicated teacher who is wholly committed to the highest ideals of public service and quality education for all, and she should be specially recognized; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we hereby honor and congratulate Tabitha Bates on her selection as a 2026 Extraordinary Educator, commend her exceptional service to the

children of Tennessee, salute her professional expertise and personal excellence, and wish her all the best in her future endeavors.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.